

D805

Secondary Disciplinary Literacy

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A chemistry teacher wants to add disciplinary literacy to her lab units. Her room has 14 lab stations and she earned a national teaching award. Which activity is disciplinary literacy rather than general content-area literacy?

- A. Students summarize each paragraph of the textbook.
- B. Students read a lab procedure and check whether the stated results match the data and methods, as chemists do.
- C. Students label all 14 lab stations.
- D. Students make predictions before reading the chapter.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A history teacher asks students to preview headings and predict what a chapter will cover. Which change would make this a disciplinary literacy task?

- A. Have students preview headings in a science book too.
- B. Have students memorize chapter dates.
- C. Have students predict with more detail.
- D. Have students compare two primary sources about the same event and explain why their accounts differ.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Eleventh graders read a 1912 letter from a factory owner praising working conditions in his mill. The letter is typed on company letterhead and is two pages long. What should students do first, as historians would?

- A. Consider who wrote it, when, and why, and how the owner's position might shape his account.
- B. Accept the letter as fact because it is a primary source.
- C. Summarize the letter's main points.
- D. Judge it reliable because it is on official letterhead.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Two accounts describe the same labor strike: one by a striking worker's diary, one by the company's press release. What is the best historical use of both?

- A.** Trust the diary because it is personal.
- B.** Discard both since both are biased.
- C.** Trust the press release because it is official.
- D.** Compare them, note how each author's position shapes the account, and check both against other evidence.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A biology text says, "The acceleration of deforestation contributes to the reduction of biodiversity." Students with IEPs are confused. The class has 30 students and uses a new online textbook. What should the teacher do?

- A.** Skip the sentence since it is too hard.
- B.** Have them look up "acceleration" in the glossary.
- C.** Help students unpack it into actions: people are cutting down forests faster, and this causes fewer kinds of living things.
- D.** Switch to the print textbook.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student writes, "Water heats up and turns into gas and goes into the air." How would a science text most likely express this?

- A.** "Evaporation occurs when water is heated."
- B.** "Condensation occurs when water is heated."
- C.** "Water gets hot and goes away."
- D.** "Water is a liquid."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A problem reads: "A club needs at least 24 members to get funding. It has 17. How many more members does it need?" A student answers "7 or fewer." The club meets in the art room on Thursdays. What reading error did the student make?

- A. He should have used the meeting day.
- B. The answer should be exactly 41.
- C. He misread "at least," which means the club needs 7 or more new members.
- D. He subtracted when he should have added.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A definition says, "A rhombus is a quadrilateral with four congruent sides." Based on this exact wording, which shape must be a rhombus?

- A. A rectangle
- B. No square can be a rhombus.
- C. A square
- D. A trapezoid

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A tenth-grade English class reads a short story in which a character keeps a broken clock. The class is reading it in October and the school's theater is performing a play based on it. Which response shows literary analysis?

- A. "The character keeps a clock, then later leaves home."
- B. "I liked the story because it was sad."
- C. "The play version will be better."
- D. "The broken clock symbolizes the character's refusal to move on, shown when she says time 'stopped' after the loss."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A science teacher asks students to write up an experiment on plant growth under different light colors. Students have been writing persuasive essays in English. The school has a greenhouse and a garden club. What should the teacher emphasize?

- A. A personal story about the garden club.
- B. The lab report structure: question, methods, data, and conclusions stated objectively and tied to results.
- C. Any format, since all writing is the same.
- D. A persuasive five-paragraph essay about why plants matter.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A ninth grader with a reading disability uses text-to-speech to access a primary source in civics. The school recently issued laptops and has fast Wi-Fi. He asks if he can just read an online summary instead. What is the best response?

- A. Keep using text-to-speech with the source itself, since the task is to analyze the document, not someone else's summary.
- B. Use the fast Wi-Fi to find more summaries.
- C. Yes, a summary covers the same learning.
- D. Stop using text-to-speech so he reads it himself.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A geometry teacher plans small-group talk after students solve a proof. The class has 27 students and meets after lunch. Which discussion structure best fits disciplinary literacy in math?

- A. Students share how they felt about the proof.
- B. Groups compare proofs, and each student must justify a step or question the reasoning in another's proof.
- C. Students take turns reading the textbook aloud.
- D. Students always agree with the group leader.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A chemistry teacher wants to add disciplinary literacy to her lab units. ~~Her room has 14 lab stations and she earned a national teaching award.~~ Which activity is disciplinary literacy rather than general content-area literacy?

Target word: which activity is disciplinary **Decides:** Reading like a chemist, not using a generic strategy.

A	Confusion set	Summarizing is content-area literacy, not field-specific.
B	Correct	Evaluating data against claims is how scientists read.
C	Camouflage	Uses the room detail; not a literacy practice.
D	Adjacent category	Predicting is a general strategy used in any subject.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

A history teacher asks students to preview headings and predict what a chapter will cover. Which change would make this a disciplinary literacy task?

Target word: convert general to disciplinary **Decides:** Add a practice specific to historians.

A	Inverted operation	Spreads the general strategy rather than making it field-specific.
B	Adjacent category	Recall is not a disciplinary reading practice.
C	Dropped element	Still a general strategy.
D	Correct	Comparing and sourcing accounts is how historians read.

3. Answer A Concept 2

Eleventh graders read a 1912 letter from a factory owner praising working conditions in his mill. ~~The letter is typed on company letterhead and is two pages long.~~ What should students do first, as historians would?

Target word: sourcing **Decides:** Author, date, purpose shape reliability.

A	Correct	Sourcing reveals the author's perspective and possible bias.
B	Absolute language	Primary sources carry their authors' perspectives.
C	Adjacent category	Summarizing skips the historian's first question.
D	Camouflage	Letterhead does not make an account objective.

4. Answer D Concept 2 • transfer

Two accounts describe the same labor strike: one by a striking worker's diary, one by the company's press release. What is the best historical use of both?

Target word: use sourcing across accounts **Decides:** Compare perspectives against each other and other evidence.

A	Inverted operation	Personal accounts also have perspective.
B	Absolute language	Biased sources still provide evidence when read critically.
C	Confusion set	Official sources have interests too.
D	Correct	Sourcing plus corroboration builds a supported interpretation.

5. Answer C Concept 3

A biology text says, “The acceleration of deforestation contributes to the reduction of biodiversity.” Students with IEPs are confused. ~~The class has 30 students and uses a new online textbook.~~ What should the teacher do?

Target word: unpack nominalization **Decides:** The sentence hides processes inside nouns.

A	Absolute language	Dense sentences carry key science ideas.
B	Dropped element	One word’s meaning does not reveal the process structure.
C	Correct	Turning the nouns back into processes reveals the meaning.
D	Camouflage	The format does not change the language.

6. Answer A Concept 3 • transfer

A student writes, “Water heats up and turns into gas and goes into the air.” How would a science text most likely express this?

Target word: reverse: form the nominalization **Decides:** Scientists pack the process into a noun.

A	Correct	Packs the process into the noun “evaporation.”
B	Confusion set	Condensation is the reverse process.
C	Inverted operation	Makes it more casual, not more scientific.
D	Dropped element	Drops the process entirely.

7. Answer C Concept 4

A problem reads: “A club needs at least 24 members to get funding. It has 17. How many more members does it need?” A student answers “7 or fewer.” ~~The club meets in the art room on Thursdays.~~ What reading error did the student make?

Target word: precise reading of math words **Decides:** “At least” means 24 or more, so 7 or more new members.

A	Camouflage	Thursday is irrelevant.
B	Wrong stem number	Adds the two numbers.
C	Correct	Small words in math set the direction of the inequality.
D	Inverted operation	$24 - 17 = 7$ is the right operation.

8. Answer C Concept 4 • transfer

A definition says, “A rhombus is a quadrilateral with four congruent sides.” Based on this exact wording, which shape must be a rhombus?

Target word: apply a definition exactly **Decides:** Any quadrilateral with four equal sides qualifies.

A	Confusion set	Rectangles need not have four equal sides.
B	Absolute language	Ignores the exact wording of the definition.
C	Correct	A square has four congruent sides, so it meets the definition.
D	Adjacent category	Its sides are not all congruent in general.

9. Answer D Concept 5

A tenth-grade English class reads a short story in which a character keeps a broken clock. ~~The class is reading it in October and the school's theater is performing a play based on it.~~ Which response shows literary analysis?

Target word: claim + evidence about craft **Decides:** Interpreting author's choice with textual support.

A	Confusion set	Plot summary without interpretation.
B	Adjacent category	A personal reaction, not analysis.
C	Camouflage	Uses the theater detail; not analysis of the text.
D	Correct	Makes a claim about craft and cites textual evidence.

10. Answer B Concept 6

A science teacher asks students to write up an experiment on plant growth under different light colors. Students have been writing persuasive essays in English. ~~The school has a greenhouse and a garden club.~~ What should the teacher emphasize?

Target word: disciplinary writing conventions **Decides:** A lab report reports methods and results objectively.

A	Camouflage	Uses the club detail; not the discipline's form.
B	Correct	Scientific writing follows its own conventions.
C	Absolute language	Each discipline has distinct writing conventions.
D	Adjacent category	A generic persuasive form, not scientific reporting.

11. Answer A Concept 7

A ninth grader with a reading disability uses text-to-speech to access a primary source in civics. ~~The school recently issued laptops and has fast Wi-Fi.~~ He asks if he can just read an online summary instead. What is the best response?

Target word: role of digital tools **Decides:** Tools support access; the disciplinary thinking must still happen with the source.

A	Correct	The tool supports access while keeping the disciplinary work.
B	Camouflage	Connection speed is irrelevant.
C	Dropped element	Drops the source analysis the task requires.
D	Inverted operation	Removes an appropriate access support.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A geometry teacher plans small-group talk after students solve a proof. ~~The class has 27 students and meets after lunch.~~ Which discussion structure best fits disciplinary literacy in math?

Target word: discipline-specific discussion **Decides:** Math talk critiques reasoning and justification.

A	Adjacent category	Feelings are not mathematical argument.
B	Correct	Critiquing reasoning is how mathematicians talk.
C	Confusion set	Reading aloud is not discussion.
D	Absolute language	Removes critique, the heart of math discussion.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Disciplinary vs. content-area literacy	Content-area literacy applies general strategies (summarizing, predicting) in any subject; disciplinary literacy teaches the specific ways experts in a field read, write, and reason.	Thinking a general reading strategy taught in science class is disciplinary literacy.	Whether the practice would look the same in every subject.
2	Sourcing in history	Historians read the source information first (who wrote it, when, for what purpose and audience) to judge perspective and reliability before reading the content.	Treating a primary source as a neutral record of facts.	A historical document with an author and date.
3	Nominalization in science text	Science writing often turns processes into nouns (“evaporation,” “the reduction of”), packing actions into dense phrases that students must unpack into who does what.	Treating these nouns as simple vocabulary words rather than hidden processes.	A dense sentence full of -tion nouns and few action verbs.
4	Precision in mathematical text	In math, every word and symbol carries exact meaning; small words (“at least,” “exactly,” “each”) and notation change the problem, so math text is read slowly and more than once.	Skimming math text for numbers and a key word.	A word problem or definition where one small word matters.
5	Literary interpretation with evidence	In English, readers make claims about meaning and author’s craft (word choice, structure, symbol) and support them with textual evidence and reasoning.	Offering personal reactions or plot summary as literary analysis.	A question about why an author made a choice.
6	Disciplinary writing forms	Each field has its own writing conventions: a lab report reports methods and results objectively; a historical argument makes a claim about the past supported by sourced evidence.	Teaching one generic essay format for every subject.	An assignment asking students to write like a scientist or historian.
7	Digital tools support, not replace, disciplinary reading	Tools such as text-to-speech, digital glossaries, and annotation help students access complex discipline texts, but students still must do the field’s thinking with the text.	Letting a tool’s summary or AI answer stand in for reading the source.	A student uses a digital tool on an assigned discipline text.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Discipline-specific academic discussion	Structured talk in each discipline has its own norms, such as critiquing mathematical reasoning or citing evidence from sources, and builds understanding before writing.	Assuming open-ended sharing of opinions is academic discussion.	A teacher plans small-group talk in a content class.

Course scope (public description): Secondary Disciplinary Literacy is a cutting-edge course designed for candidates seeking to enhance their literacy skills within specific secondary academic disciplines. The course examines the distinct literacy needs of various secondary content areas, focusing on how reading, writing, speaking, and listening function differently in each discipline. Candidates will explore specialized language structures and text features relevant to each field and develop strategies to help students master these complexities. The curriculum integrates the science of reading to support critical engagement with and production of disciplinary texts, while also incorporating technology and digital literacy to aid students in accessing and interpreting discipline-specific information. The course combines research-based evidence with practical, structured literacy activities to equip educators with the skills necessary to improve student achievement and understanding across all subjects. This course is a required component in SCED programs and will be assessed through a performance assessment task for both undergraduate and graduate versions.